

Bullying the PARTNERS

Cracks are deepening within the ruling coalition as a belligerent Congress is threatening to go it alone

| By Priya Sahgal |

A junior Congress leader recently took a potshot at Agriculture Minister Sharad Pawar's handling of the drought situation. Since Pawar is also the leader of the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) and a UPA ally for over a decade, some NCP workers were enraged. Their leader, however, did not react. After all, this was not the first time he had been criticised by his allies. As he told his colleagues, such attacks are a part of the Congress party's fabled coalition dharma. The DMK would probably agree.

Fresh from the Lok Sabha win, the party had tested its new-found power of 206 seats by dictating whom the DMK could include in the Cabinet. More recently, when the Congress leadership played hard to get and refused to meet a DMK delegation, M. Karunanidhi decided to send a message of his own. In a subtle hint that he should not be taken for granted, the DMK supremo recently cosied up to a BJP chief minister next door. He has shared the dais with the BJP's B.S. Yeddyurappa on not one but two occasions in the past few weeks.

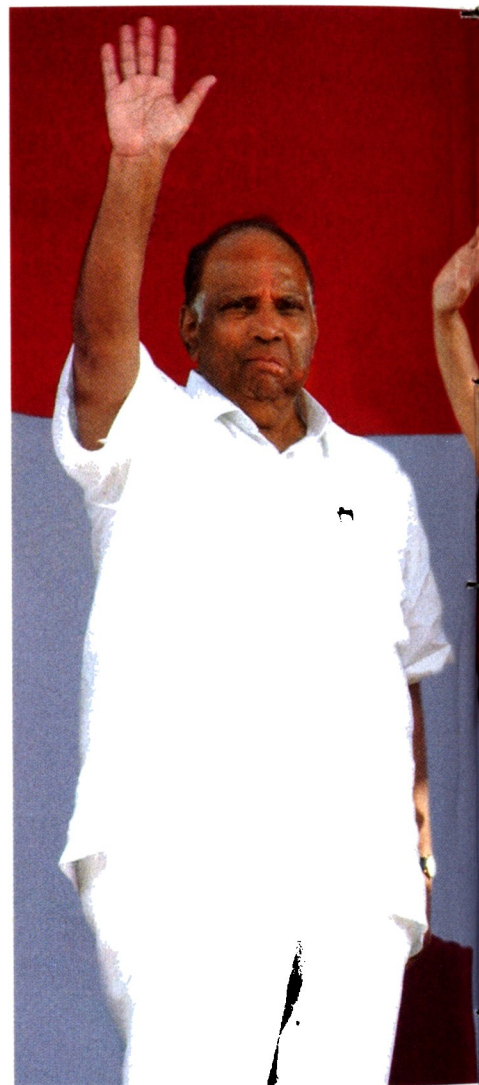
With the Maharashtra elections round the corner, the party is yet to finalise its seat-sharing pact with the NCP. Despite its bravado of wanting to go it alone, an internal assessment has shown that the Congress cannot return to power in Maharashtra on its own. It needs a tie-up with the NCP. The first signs have not been very encouraging with General Secretary Digvijay Singh even suggesting that

the NCP should merge with the Congress. This has not gone down too well with Pawar who dismissed this suggestion as "cheap publicity", telling the media that "they (Congress) should not talk like that... there are some of our friends in the Congress, I think, who prefer to discuss major issues publicly and want to get some publicity". However, is cheap publicity all that Digvijay is seeking?

The seasoned Thakur has emerged as Rahul Gandhi's right-hand man in the Congress and the young scion has made his stand against coalitions quite clear. Even before the Lok Sabha polls when the Congress had engaged with the Samajwadi Party (SP) in seat-sharing talks, it was Digvijay who scuttled the talks with his hard bargaining. And his trusted aide Satyavrat Chaturvedi launched a personal attack against the SP leadership. That alliance failed to take off. There is an uncanny feeling of déjà vu in the NCP camp as the Digvijay and Chaturvedi duo play out a familiar script. It was Chaturvedi who had questioned Pawar's drought management measures. Now again sundry Congressmen are talking about replicating the Uttar Pradesh model in Maharashtra, citing the case of the Lok Sabha polls where it won 17 seats to the NCP's seven. The NCP is upset with Congress leaders like Vilasrao Deshmukh who are advocating a post-poll instead of a pre-poll alliance. "Ten years ago, we fought separately but then the Congress had

to come to us to form the government," Pawar told the media. But the Congress is in no mood to learn from the past. Even though fighting alone may give the BJP and Shiv Sena an edge, with no reasonable overtures coming from the Congress, the NCP is readying its cadres to fight the Assembly polls by itself.

A poor show in the recent round of bypolls has not taken away the high of the Lok Sabha win from the Congress. In Karnataka, the party won only one of the five by-elections even though four of these were Congress-held seats. In Uttar Pradesh, it lost its deposit in two of the four seats, winning



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